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Orienteering In Nervous Conditions

“‘And they buried the hunger artist along with the straw. But in his cage they put a young panther. Even for a person with the dumbest mind it was clearly refreshing to see this wild animal throwing itself around in this cage, which had been dreary for such a long time. It lacked nothing. Without thinking about it for any length of time, the guards brought the animal food. It enjoyed the taste and never seemed to miss its freedom. This noble body, equipped with everything necessary, almost to the point of bursting, also appeared to carry freedom around with it. That seem to be located somewhere or other in its teeth, and its joy in living came with such strong passion from its throat that it was not easy for spectators to keep watching. But they controlled themselves, kept pressing around the cage, and had no desire to move on. ”’

Intro/Abstract

“As if it is ever easy, And these days it is worse, with the poverty of blackness on one side and the weight of womanhood on the other”

Nervous Conditions; as it concludes, is a story of women. Women who are divided, complex, and despite all living in the same space, women who plot their course through it very differently. Dangaremba says *“People make individual choices. I think mapping the ground helps in making the choices. Such maps, written in an engaging way, are part of what I perceive some of my responsibility as a novelist to be.”* In viewing this novel as a map - or rather an atlas - with the characters each as a map. The worldly Nyasha: a rebellious and neurotic youth, archetypal of the bildungsroman's hero and the main character Tambu: an obedient and poor child, with a deep yearning to be free of her colonial shackles. Finally, Lucia: older and mysterious, with a seemingly magical ability to shape the world to her will. Continuing the metaphor, the roads, the vessels that direct traffic through the map, and how the characters control their fates are paved with two themes: Food and Education. This essay will inspect each how each character cuts her own path, culminating in Lucia's.

Nyasha, Oh Starving!

“They do not like my language , my English, because it is authentic and my Shona, because it is not!” Nyasha is the character most affected by the titular ‘nervous conditions’. For Nyasha food, is Her and her mother, Maiguru are the only women who have lived outside of Africa. For Nyasha food is symbolic of so much; locale since she has “tasted” what it feels like to not be in Africa. This is seen when she returns from England. *“Nyasha tucked into the vegetables with the rest of us. When my mother offered her the sour milk she had asked for, she became very morose. She refused to eat”* . Nyasha wishes to not be in the physical space that she is and so she rejects the food that is representative of that. Food to Nyasha is also a cudgel her father uses to control her.

“I’m not hungry,’ Nyasha explained.

“You will eat that food,’ commanded the man. ”Your mother and I are not killing ourselves working just for you to waste your time playing with boys and then come back and turn up your nose at what we offer. Sit and eat that food. I am telling you. Eat it!’ Nyasha took a few mouthfuls.

‘She has had enough, Baba,’ Maiguru said, but Babamukuru was adamant. He was very upset.

‘She must eat her food, all of it. She is always doing this, challenging me. I am her father. If she doesn’t want to do what I say, I shall stop providing for her - fees, clothes, food, everything.’

‘Nyasha, eat your food,’ her mother advised. ‘Christ!’ Nyasha breathed and with a shrug picked up her fork and began to eat, slowly at first, then gobbling the food down without a break. The atmosphere lightened with every mouthful she took.”

While an entire essay could be written on this scene; for this essay, this scene lays bare how “the man” sees not eating the food he provides as a challenge to his authority. In this moment he is not Babamukuru, Nyasha’s father, but instead the man or even just men.

Education

For Nyasha her education is her undoing. She knows the power food has and as such has the wisdom to think she must reject it. Nyasha

Tambu forces food down

Tambu's interaction with colonialism

Tambu has an odd relationship with colonialism in that she is obviously one of the most affected by it in the book,

Her Relation to food

Tambu's relation to food mirrors her relation to education. Food is a means to escape. We see this literally in the beginning when she is able to pay for her schooling by selling food. She differs from Nyasha in that African food is authentic to her. Compared to Babamakuru's whole family even she was the only one who liked sadza *"I was very pleased to see the sadza when it came, although nobody else seemed to care for it. This was embarrassing. There were many things that were embarrassing about that meal: my place looked as though a small and angry child had been fed there; here I was with a spoon in my hand instead of a fork and now Maiguru was dishing sadza on to my plate, sadza that nobody else would eat"*

Her relation to education

Tambu loves learning, for 'selfish' reasons (nearly everyone in this book is 'selfish') Tambu believes that if she is educated enough she will not have to marry, or at least will have far more freedom than she would if she was not educated. She enjoys education and takes to it well. Connecting to food, she does not turn it down, and instead uses it to hopefully get her where she wants to be.

Lucia, a middle ground?

If Tambu and Nyasha live chart paths around a mountain, Lucia simply climbs it. Despite the topographical lines being so dense they nearly touch, Lucia's path cuts through them. On first glance, this in part can be attributed to her naivete, she truly doesn't

Her Relation to food

Lucia has so many oddly masculine attributes. She is able to provide not just food, but meat. and is somehow magically always well fed.

Her Relation to education